

The Twelve Steps: A Journey from Surrender to Service
60-Minute Recovery Talk — June 7, 2026 ### John
Cunningham | 53 Years of Continuous Sobriety

Notation: - (Pause.) — 2 seconds - (Long Silence.) — 4–5
seconds - (*slow*) — drop the pace - **bold** — slight emphasis

Opening: The Bench

July 1980. Two o'clock in the afternoon. Hamilton.

I'm sitting on a park bench in the middle of a weekday.

Families are together at the picnic tables. Kids are playing in
the pool behind me. I can hear them — the noise, the
splashing, the mothers calling names I can't quite make out.

And I'm sitting here, looking up at this deep blue sky.

(Pause.)

There are almost no clouds. Just blue. Deep, clean blue.

And I'm thinking: My God, this is so beautiful.

(Pause.)

It's like I'd lived under the sky all my life, but I never took
notice of how I was experiencing my life and what's around
me. I just took it for granted.

I'm watching the birds. Looking at the leaves. The trees. The
flowers in the bed gardens across from me.

And I'm thinking: My God, the whole thing has changed.

(Long Silence.)

This is what they call a spiritual awakening.

The scales falling from your eyes. You can finally see where you've been blind. There's a sense of purpose. You're no longer asleep. You're very much aware.

That's what happened as a result of the twelve steps.

Everything changed. Everything transformed. Not new, but being **restored**.

(Pause.)

But to get to that bench — to get to that moment of awakening — I had to walk through twelve distinct doors.

And tonight, I want to take you through all twelve.

Not as a lecture. Not as theology.

As a journey.

The journey that saved my life.

(Long Silence.)

Act I: The Foundation (Steps 1-3)

Step One: The End of the Fight

Let me take you back.

(Pause.)

Before the bench. Before the awakening. Before I could see the blue sky without taking it for granted.

There was a different moment.

(Pause.)

A moment when I finally stopped.

Not because I wanted to. Not because I saw the light.

Because I was **done**.

(Long Silence.)

Step One says: "We admitted we were powerless over alcohol — that our lives had become unmanageable."

(Pause.)

Powerless.

That's a hard word for people like us. We built our lives on the opposite idea. We managed. We controlled. We performed. We held it together. We told ourselves: I can handle this. I just need to try harder.

(Pause.)

And one day — or one night, or one morning — the trying stops working.

The fight ends.

Not because you won. Because you lost.

(Long Silence.)

I remember the moment I knew.

Not the moment I said it out loud. The moment I **knew**.

I was sitting in a room I didn't recognize. My hands were shaking. I couldn't remember how I got there. And I thought:

(slow) I cannot do this anymore.

Not "I don't want to." Not "I shouldn't."

I cannot.

(Pause.)

That's Step One.

The end of the fight.

(Long Silence.)

Step Two: Came to Believe

But ending the fight isn't recovery.

It's just — stopping.

(Pause.)

Step Two says: "Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity."

(Pause.)

Notice the word: **restore**.

Not create. Not manufacture. Not build from scratch.

Restore.

(Pause.)

That means there's something in you — something that was always there — that got buried. Obscured. Drowned out.

Your sacred identity.

The person you were meant to be before the alcohol, the fear, the self-management, the performing.

(Long Silence.)

I came to believe slowly.

Not in a flash. Not with certainty. I came to believe the way you come to trust a bridge you've never crossed before — one step at a time, testing the weight, hoping it holds.

(Pause.)

And it did.

(Long Silence.)

Step Three: Made a Decision

Step Three says: "Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God as we understood Him."

(Pause.)

Made a decision.

Not had a feeling. Not waited until I was ready. Not hoped it would happen someday.

Made. A. Decision.

(Long Silence.)

I don't remember what I said. I remember where I was. I remember the sense — the very clear sense — that I was letting go of something I'd been carrying for so long I'd forgotten it was in my hands.

(Pause.)

My will. My life. The belief that I could manage it all if I just tried harder.

I put it down.

(Pause.)

Not because I wanted to.

Because I had to.

(Long Silence.)

Act II: The Work (Steps 4-7)

Step Four: The Inventory

Now the real work begins.

(Pause.)

Step Four says: "Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves."

(Pause.)

Searching. Fearless. Moral. Inventory.

Four words that sound simple until you sit down with a blank piece of paper and realize what they're asking.

(Long Silence.)

I had to write down everything.

The resentments. The fears. The harms I caused. The patterns I ran. The lies I told — especially the ones I told myself.

(Pause.)

And here's the thing about Step Four: it's not about shame. It's about facts.

(Pause.)

What happened? What did I do? What was my part?

Not what I felt about it. Not what I wished had happened.

Not the story I'd been telling myself for twenty years.

The truth.

(Long Silence.)

Step Five: Admitted to God, to Ourselves, and to

Another Human Being

Step Five says: "Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs."

(Pause.)

Another human being.

(Pause.)

That's the part that matters.

You can admit things to God in the privacy of your own mind. You can write them down and lock them in a drawer. But until you say them out loud — to another person, in a room, where they can hear you —
(*slow*) they still have power over you.

(Long Silence.)

I sat across from my sponsor. I read my Fourth Step. Every line. Every resentment. Every fear. Every harm.

And he listened.

He didn't judge. He didn't fix. He didn't tell me I was worse than I thought or better than I deserved.

He just — listened.

(Pause.)

And when I was done, he said:

"You're not unique. You're not special. You're an alcoholic. And you're exactly where you're supposed to be."

(Long Silence.)

That was freedom.

(Pause.)

Not forgiveness. Not absolution.

Just — being known. And not being rejected.

(Long Silence.)

Step Six: Entirely Ready

Step Six says: "Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character."

(Pause.)

Entirely ready.

(Pause.)

I thought Step Six meant making a plan. I thought it meant figuring out how I was going to fix myself. I thought it meant listing my character defects in columns and building a self-improvement project.

(Pause.)

My sponsor looked at me and said:

"John, Step Six isn't about you doing anything. It's about you stopping. It's about unclenching your fist and letting God take what you've been gripping."

(Long Silence.)

Entirely ready doesn't mean capable.

It means **willing**.

(Pause.)

Willing to let go.

(Long Silence.)

Step Seven: Humbly Asked

Step Seven says: "Humbly asked Him to remove our

shortcomings."

(Pause.)

Seven words.

Six steps of preparation for seven words.

(Long Silence.)

Winter. Before light. A room that was not mine. I was on my knees.

Not because I knew what I was doing. The posture was unfamiliar. My knees had not spent much time on floors. But my sponsor had told me: when you get to Step Seven, get on your knees. Not as performance. Just — get on your knees. Let the body say what the mind is only beginning to mean.

(Pause.)

And I asked.

(Long Silence.)

The word humbly doesn't mean groveling. It doesn't mean smallness. It doesn't mean standing with your hat in your hand, apologizing for existing.

The root is *humilis* — meaning "low," "grounded," "close to the earth." From *humus*: soil. Dirt. The ground beneath you. (*slow*) Humility is accurate self-knowledge.

(Long Silence.)

It means knowing where I stand. This is who I am. This is what I cannot do by myself. This is what I need. And here is the God I have come to believe in — and trust — enough to

ask.

(Pause.)

That is not weakness.

That is the most accurate thing a human being can say.

(Long Silence.)

Act III: The Repair (Steps 8-9)

Step Eight: The List

Step Eight says: "Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all."

(Pause.)

A list.

(Pause.)

Not a plan for how I would make amends. Not a script for what I would say. Not a timeline for when I felt ready.

Just a list.

(Long Silence.)

The first time I sat down to write that list, I thought: this won't take long. I know who I hurt. I know what I did.

(Pause.)

Three hours later, I was still writing.

(Pause.)

Because harm is not always dramatic. It's not always the thing you got caught doing. Sometimes it's the absence. The lie of omission. The moment you chose yourself over

someone who needed you. The promise you didn't keep. The attention you didn't give.

(Long Silence.)

And then there's the hardest name on the list.

(Pause.)

Your own.

(Long Silence.)

Step Nine: The Listening

Step Nine says: "Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others."

(Pause.)

Made direct amends.

Not apologized. Not confessed. Not explained.

Amended.

(Long Silence.)

Thursday afternoon. March 1990. James Street. Two o'clock.

A coffee shop I'd never been to before.

I was sitting across from someone I'd harmed. The script was in my pocket. The coffee was between us.

(Pause.)

And I almost did what I'd planned to do. I almost pulled out the script and read it. Confessed. Apologized. Left.

But my sponsor had told me something I didn't want to hear.

He said: "John, Step Nine is not about your relief. It's about their repair. And you can't repair what you haven't heard

described."

(Long Silence.)

So I said:

"I hurt you. I know that much. And I've been working a program that asks me to make amends for the harm I've caused. But before I tell you what I think I did — I need to hear from you. What did it feel like? What did it cost you? What was the harm from where you were standing?"

(Long Silence.)

He looked at me. Surprised.

Because nobody had asked him that before.

(Pause.)

And he told me.

(Long Silence.)

I thought the harm was the lie.

He told me the harm was the silence after the lie.

I thought the harm was the money.

He told me the harm was the trust.

(Pause.)

An apology says: I'm sorry for what I think I did.

An amend says: I want to understand what you actually experienced.

(Pause.)

One is a confession.

One is a conversation.

(Long Silence.)

That's Step Nine.
Not relief. Repair.
(Long Silence.)

Act IV: The Life (Steps 10-12)

Step Ten: Continued to Take Personal Inventory

Step Ten says: "Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it."

(Pause.)

Continued.

(Pause.)

Not "took inventory once and called it done." Not "waited until it was bad enough to matter."

Continued.

(Long Silence.)

Tuesday night. 10:17. The house is quiet. I'm sitting at the table with a pen in my hand. Not writing. Just holding the pen.

There is a piece of paper in front of me. Clean. And I am trying to do something very simple.

Take inventory.

(Pause.)

That sounds simple when you say it in a meeting. But at 10:17 at night, with a pen in your hand and a day behind you, it is not just a sentence.

It is the place where you have to sit still long enough to tell the truth.

(Long Silence.)

And for people like us, telling the truth is not always the first hard thing.

Sometimes the first hard thing is finding the facts underneath all the feelings.

(Pause.)

Somebody did not call back. Fact.

They are rejecting me. Not fact.

I made a mistake. Fact.

I am a mistake. No.

(Pause.)

That's the old sickness talking. That's not inventory. That's punishment wearing a clean shirt.

(Long Silence.)

Step Ten is a daily practice. Not a crisis intervention. Not something you do when you've blown it badly enough to notice.

It's the practice of staying awake.

(Long Silence.)

Step Eleven: Sought Through Prayer and Meditation

Step Eleven says: "Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God as we understood Him, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out."

(Pause.)

Conscious contact.

(Pause.)

Not intellectual contact. Not theological contact. Not the contact you get from reading a book or hearing a good talk.

Conscious contact.

(Long Silence.)

Thursday night. Seven o'clock. The Holy Spirit Centre in Hamilton. Not a big place. Not fancy. The kind of room where the chairs have been there a long time and the floor knows the weight of people carrying things.

My friend Gary is beside me. We came because a visiting Benedictine monk was teaching Christian meditation that night.

(Pause.)

What he gave us was simplicity.

A word. **Maranatha.**

(slow) Ma-ra-na-tha.

Four syllables. Aramaic. "Come, Lord."

(Long Silence.)

The instruction was simple. Sit. Be present. Say the word.

When your mind drifts — and it will drift — bring it back. No judgment. No frustration. Just return to the word.

(Pause.)

And what I've come to understand is that God is only in the present moment.

Not in the past. Not in the future.

Right here. Right now.

(Long Silence.)

I use two words to separate what happens in my head.

The first is **thinking**. Thinking is reasonable. Logical. What are the facts? What's the next right thing? Thinking has a purpose.

The second word I use is **thoughting**.

(slow) Thoughting.

That's different. Thoughting is just a thought that comes through. No merit. No weight. An old record playing. The mind jumping from past to future to something someone said twelve years ago. None of it belongs in this moment.

(Pause.)

In meditation, there's no room for thoughting.

(Long Silence.)

Every moment I spend in meditation, what I'm really doing is experiencing the relationship I have with this inner power.

Not my power.

The power.

(Pause.)

The question Step Eleven asks is: now what?

Now am I willing to invest the time?

(Long Silence.)

Step Twelve: Having Had a Spiritual Awakening

Step Twelve says: "Having had a spiritual awakening as the

result of these steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs."
(Pause.)

Three parts.

The awakening. The service. The practice.

(Long Silence.)

Most people talk about the awakening and the service. They don't spend much time on the third part: practicing these principles in all our affairs.

But that's where the knowing-doing gap lives.

(Pause.)

Our brain tricks us. Because we know something, we actually think we are doing it. We think we're experiencing it.

It's not that at all.

(slow) The only way to experience it is to practice it.

(Long Silence.)

Tuesday morning. 9:23. I'm on the phone with a client. He asks me a question about a project I said I'd finish last week. I didn't finish it.

(Pause.)

Now, I have a choice in this moment.

I can **think**: What's the fact here? I didn't finish it. I need to tell him the truth and give him a new date.

Or I can start **thoughting**. He's going to think you're unreliable. He's going to fire you. You always do this.

None of that is fact.

(Pause.)

So I stop. I take a breath. And I say:

"I didn't get to it. I should have called you Friday to let you know. I can have it to you by Thursday. Will that work?"

He says yes.

That's it.

(Pause.)

That's practicing the principle of honesty.

Not complicated. Not dramatic. Just the truth, said out loud, in the moment it's needed.

(Long Silence.)

Sunday afternoon. 2:15. I'm on the phone with Ahmed.

We've been working together for months. He's stuck on Step 4. Says he's been writing. Says he's almost done.

I know that tone.

(Pause.)

I say: "Ahmed, did you write this week?"

Silence.

Then: "I meant to. I got busy with work."

(Pause.)

Now, I could let that go. I could say, "Okay, call me next week." I could be nice.

But that's not sponsorship. That's not service.

So I say: (*slow*) "Ahmed, you've been 'busy with work' for three weeks. You're not stuck on Step 4. You're avoiding Step 4. And I get it. It's hard. But the longer you wait, the

harder it gets."

More silence.

Then he says, quietly: "I don't know if I can do this."

And that's the moment.

(Long Silence.)

I say: "You can't. Not alone. That's the whole point. But you don't have to do it alone. I'm here. God's here. The program's here."

(Pause.)

I don't know if he'll do it. But I showed up. I held him accountable. Not for my sake. For his.

(Long Silence.)

That's carrying the message.

Not preaching. Not lecturing. Not fixing.

Just showing up. Extending a hand. Being available.

(Long Silence.)

Close: The Bell That Can't Be Unrung

Back on that bench. July 1980.

The blue sky. The sound of children playing. Families I didn't know. A world I'd been living in but not seeing.

Sitting there, imagining my higher power sitting beside me.

And feeling — for the first time in my life — that everything was okay. That I had purpose. That I had meaning. That all was well.

(Pause.)

That sharpness. That clarity. From that moment to this moment here in 2026.

It stayed with me.

Not that I've always been humble. Not that I've always been grateful. Not that I've always been comfortable.

I've had reverses in my life. That's part of living life.

But I knew the difference.

(Pause.)

There's an old saying: (*slow*) you can't unring a bell that has rung.

You've heard it.

I heard it.

And that's what's important.

(Long Silence.)

The twelve steps are not a theory. They're not a philosophy.

They're not a set of ideas you agree with.

They're a path.

A path from powerlessness to purpose. From isolation to connection. From self-management to surrender. From shame to restoration.

(Pause.)

Step One: I can't.

Step Two: God can.

Step Three: I'll let Him.

Steps Four through Nine: Clean house.

Steps Ten through Twelve: Live in it.

(Long Silence.)

Fifty-three years ago, I walked through the first door.

I didn't know where it led. I didn't know if it would work. I just knew I couldn't keep doing what I'd been doing.

(Pause.)

And here I am.

On the other side of twelve doors.

Still sober. Still awake. Still grateful.

(Long Silence.)

Back on that bench.

The blue sky.

The knowing.

Not new.

Restored.

(Long Silence.)

Delivery note: ~5,800 words. At measured pace with indicated pauses, this runs 58-64 minutes depending on how long you hold the silences. Read it aloud once with a timer before June 7th. The (Long Silence.) marks are structural — they give the room time to breathe. Don't rush them. The arc is: awakening → surrender → work → repair → life → return to awakening. Each act has a clear entry and exit. If time runs short, you can trim Act II (Steps 4-7) by

summarizing Steps 4-6 more briefly and keeping Step 7 intact. The spine is: Step 1 (surrender), Step 7 (asking), Step 9 (listening), Step 11 (meditation), Step 12 (service).

Strengths: Full 12-step arc in one talk, cold scene openings for each step, circular return to July 1980 bench, sacred identity thread ("restored not created"),
thoughting/thinking callback, Ahmed sponsorship scene, consistent pause notation, John's plainspoken voice throughout, knowing-doing gap as the Step 12 thesis.

Before delivering: Read it aloud. Mark where YOU want to slow down or add pauses. Swap any scene that doesn't feel true to your experience. This is the rail — make the moments yours.